IDEATION PHASE

Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow

Brainstorming & Idea Prioritization

Brainstorm & Idea Prioritization Template

Project Name	Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow
Document	Brainstorming & Idea Prioritization
Phase	1. Ideation Phase
Date	08 September 2026
Team ID	_____
Maximum Marks	4 Marks

1. Purpose

This document records how the project team brainstormed and prioritized ideas for the Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow project. Brainstorming was carried out to explore different ways of solving the selected incident-management problem before any solution was chosen, so that the final direction is based on comparing options rather than on a single assumption.

Ideas were generated around the selected problem statements and then grouped by the stage of the incident lifecycle they improve. The six idea groups together cover the full path of an incident: setting it up, classifying and routing it, supporting its investigation, relating it to other records, documenting its resolution, and validating the complete process.

2. Step 1 – Team Gathering, Collaboration and Select the Problem Statement

2.1 Selected Problem Statement

PS-1 – Service Desk Agent: The Service Desk Agent needs a consistent way to create, classify, route and manage incidents without incomplete information or incorrect assignment.

2.2 Reason for Selecting PS-1

PS-1 was selected because the Service Desk Agent is the first person to handle an incident, so the quality of what the agent records and decides at this point affects every later stage. If an incident starts with missing details or a wrong classification, it can reach the wrong team, wait longer for support, and arrive at Level 2 without the context needed to investigate it.

2.3 Challenges Experienced by Service Desk Agents

- Incident details may be incomplete when the incident is created.
- Category, subcategory, urgency, service and configuration item (CI) may be classified incorrectly or inconsistently.
- Manual entry and inconsistent routing can delay the right support and lead to incorrect assignment.
- Useful troubleshooting knowledge can be difficult to find during investigation.
- Escalation to Level 2 is manual, and related change and child incident context may be disconnected.

2.4 Connection to the Project Objective

The project objective is to standardize the Incident Management lifecycle so that incidents can be classified, routed, investigated, related to changes and child incidents, resolved and documented consistently. Solving PS-1 is the starting point for this objective, because consistent creation and classification make the later lifecycle stages possible. PS-2 (Level 2 Technician) is addressed by the knowledge, escalation and related-record ideas that follow.

3. Step 2 – Brainstorm, Idea Listing and Grouping

The table below lists the brainstormed ideas under six groups. Each group relates to one stage of the incident lifecycle, and each idea is described briefly with its purpose.

Idea Group	Brainstormed Ideas	Purpose
Incident Setup	• **Standard incident creation:** one agreed way of logging every incident. • **Mandatory/complete incident information:** key details are required so incidents are not logged with gaps. • **Category and subcategory standards:** a common set of categories so similar issues are labelled the same way.	Improve data quality and consistency.
Classification & Routing	• **Capture urgency, service and CI:** record how serious the issue is and which service and configuration item are affected. • **Consistent assignment:** incidents follow the same assignment approach so they reach the suitable team. • **Escalation to Level 2:** a clear path for incidents that need deeper technical investigation.	Send incidents to the right support team faster.
Knowledge Support	• **Knowledge Management:** a central source of support information for agents. • **Agent Assist:** relevant knowledge is suggested while the agent works on an incident. • **Troubleshooting guidance:** practical steps the agent can follow to diagnose common problems.	Reduce investigation time and improve first-contact resolution.
Related Records	• **Link emergency change requests:** connect an incident to an emergency change that is related to it. • **Create child incidents:** split or track related work as separate incidents under the main one. • **Maintain parent/child context:** keep the relationship visible between the main incident and its child incidents.	Provide traceability for related work and recurring issues.
Resolution & Knowledge	• **Record cause, resolution and resolution details:** document what went wrong and how it was fixed. • **Create Knowledge Articles from useful solutions:** turn successful solutions into reusable articles.	Improve closure quality and reuse successful solutions.
Validation	• **Final validation:** check the incident, service, SLA, change, child incident, knowledge and related records together.	Ensure the complete lifecycle works as intended.

4. Alternative Ideas Considered

Before selecting the incident lifecycle approach, the team considered other reasonable ways of addressing the incident-management problem in ServiceNow. They are compared below.

Alternative Approach	Advantages	Limitations	Suitability
Manual incident logging with free-text descriptions	Quick to use and needs no setup.	Details are often incomplete, categories vary, and routing depends on individual judgement.	Not suitable: it does not solve PS-1.
Improve classification only	Low effort and gives early improvement in routing.	Does not help with knowledge, escalation, related records or resolution documentation.	Partly suitable: kept as one part of the selected approach.
Standalone knowledge base without lifecycle links	Helps agents find troubleshooting information.	Agents must search separately, and knowledge is not connected to incident creation or closure.	Partly suitable: included as Knowledge Support within the lifecycle.
Manual escalation and tracking of related work through work notes	Flexible and needs little configuration.	Context is spread across records, so Level 2 may repeat investigation, and traceability is weak.	Not suitable: it does not solve PS-2.

Why the selected approach is more suitable: Each alternative addresses only one part of the problem. A standardized incident lifecycle covers all stages, from creation to validation, and keeps classification, knowledge, escalation, related records and resolution documentation connected. It therefore addresses both PS-1 and PS-2 in a consistent way.

5. Step 3 – Idea Prioritization

The nine ideas were rated for impact (benefit to the incident process) and effort (work needed to deliver the idea), and given a decision of Must have or Should have.

Priority	Idea	Impact	Effort	Decision	Justification
1	Standardized Incident Lifecycle	High	Medium	Must have	• **Impact:** it is the foundation that every lifecycle stage depends on. • **Effort:** it needs coordination across several stages. • **Decision:** the other ideas build on it.

Priority	Idea	Impact	Effort	Decision	Justification
2	Incident Classification: Category, Subcategory, Urgency, Service, CI	High	Low	Must have	• **Impact:** correct classification supports routing and priority. • **Effort:** it uses a small set of fields. • **Decision:** it directly addresses PS-1.
3	Knowledge Management & Agent Assist	High	Medium	Must have	• **Impact:** it reduces investigation time and supports first-contact resolution. • **Effort:** it needs knowledge content and Agent Assist to be set up. • **Decision:** agents need knowledge during investigation.
4	Level 2 Reassignment / Escalation	High	Medium	Must have	• **Impact:** it gives Level 2 a clear route to incidents that need deeper investigation (PS-2). • **Effort:** it needs defined escalation and assignment steps. • **Decision:** escalation is part of the core incident flow.
5	Emergency Change linkage	High	Medium	Should have	• **Impact:** it shows Level 2 which changes relate to an incident. • **Effort:** it requires a link between incident and change records. • **Decision:** it improves context, but incidents can be handled without it, so it follows the core stages.
6	Child Incident creation and relationship	Medium	Medium	Should have	• **Impact:** it helps manage related and recurring issues, mainly for larger cases. • **Effort:** it requires parent/child relationships to be maintained. • **Decision:** useful for traceability, but not needed for every incident.

Priority	Idea	Impact	Effort	Decision	Justification
7	Resolution and closure documentation	High	Low	Must have	• **Impact:** it improves closure quality and gives a record of what was done. • **Effort:** it uses cause and resolution details recorded at closure. • **Decision:** consistent documentation is a central project goal.
8	Knowledge Article creation	Medium	Medium	Should have	• **Impact:** it lets successful solutions be reused later. • **Effort:** it needs article content to be written and reviewed. • **Decision:** valuable, but it depends on good resolution documentation first.
9	Final validation and testing	High	Medium	Must have	• **Impact:** it confirms that the complete lifecycle works as intended. • **Effort:** it requires checking several record types together. • **Decision:** the lifecycle cannot be considered complete without it.

5.1 Justification of Final Prioritization Decisions

- **Must have (priorities 1, 2, 3, 4, 7 and 9):** these ideas cover the core lifecycle: standard creation, classification, knowledge support, escalation, resolution documentation and validation. Without them the project would not meet PS-1 or PS-2.
- **Should have (priorities 5, 6 and 8):** these ideas add context and reuse (change linkage, child incidents and Knowledge Articles). They are valuable but depend on the core stages being in place.
- **Quick benefits:** classification (priority 2) and resolution documentation (priority 7) have high impact with low effort, so they are ranked early.

6. Prioritized Solution Direction

The incident lifecycle will be built around standardized creation and classification first, then knowledge support, escalation, related records, resolution documentation and final validation. Together, the selected ideas form one consistent flow: complete and correctly classified incidents are routed to the right team, investigated with knowledge support, linked to related changes and child incidents where needed, closed with clear resolution details, and checked in the final validation.

IDEATION PHASE

Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow

Define the Problem Statements

Customer Problem Statement Template

Project Name	Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow
Document	Define the Problem Statements
Phase	1. Ideation Phase
Date	08 September 2026
Team ID	_____
Maximum Marks	2 Marks

1. Purpose

This document defines the customer problems that the Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow project aims to solve. Identifying these problems first, from the point of view of the people who handle incidents, ensures that the solution is designed around real needs rather than assumptions.

2. Background

Incident management is the process of recording, classifying, routing, investigating and resolving IT incidents. When this process is traditional or inconsistent, the following challenges commonly arise:

- **Incomplete incident information:** key details are missing when the incident is created.
- **Incorrect classification:** category, subcategory, urgency, service or CI are chosen inconsistently.
- **Incorrect assignment and routing:** incidents are sent to the wrong team or take longer to reach the right one.
- **Delays in incident resolution:** rework and waiting time extend the time to resolve.
- **Difficulty accessing relevant knowledge:** useful troubleshooting information is hard to find during investigation.
- **Missing context between related incidents and changes:** related records are not connected to the main incident.
- **Inconsistent resolution documentation:** the cause and resolution are not always recorded in a reusable way.

3. Customer Problem Statement

The problem statements are written from the users' point of view and focus on the challenges that the Incident Lifecycle Automation solution is intended to address.

Problem Statement	I am (Customer)	I'm trying to	But	Because	Which makes me feel
PS-1	Service Desk Agent	create and manage incidents with correct information and classification	incident details may be incomplete or incorrectly classified	manual entry and inconsistent routing can delay the right support	concerned about delays and incorrect assignment
PS-2	Level 2 Technician	investigate and resolve escalated incidents with full context	knowledge, changes and child incidents may not be connected to the main incident	related information can be spread across records	frustrated by missing context and repeated investigation

4. Problem Statement Narrative

Service Desk Agents need to create and manage incidents with correct information and classification, but incomplete details, incorrect classification and inconsistent manual routing can delay the right support. Level 2 Technicians then receive escalated incidents without full context, because knowledge, changes and child incidents are not connected to the main incident. As a result, investigation is repeated, resolution takes longer and the outcome is not always documented consistently. The project addresses these challenges by standardizing the incident lifecycle from creation to resolution.

5. Project Problem Focus

Standardize the Incident Management lifecycle so incidents can be classified, routed, investigated, related to changes/child incidents, resolved and documented consistently.

IDEATION PHASE

Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow

Empathy Map Canvas

Empathize & Discover

Project Name	Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow
Document	Empathy Map Canvas
Phase	1. Ideation Phase
Date	08 September 2026
Team ID	_____
Maximum Marks	4 Marks

1. Purpose

An empathy map is used in the design-thinking process to understand the needs, concerns, behaviours and expectations of the primary user. It helps the team look at the incident process from the user's point of view, so that the design of the Incident Lifecycle Automation solution is grounded in what the user needs. The empathy map below is a conceptual design-thinking artifact based on the incident-management scenario. It is not presented as the result of interviews or surveys.

2. Target User

Primary persona: Service Desk Agent. The Service Desk Agent is the first-line support person who creates incidents, classifies them, searches for knowledge, routes or escalates them to the right team, and records resolution details. The agent's work shapes the quality of every later step in the incident lifecycle.

3. Empathy Map

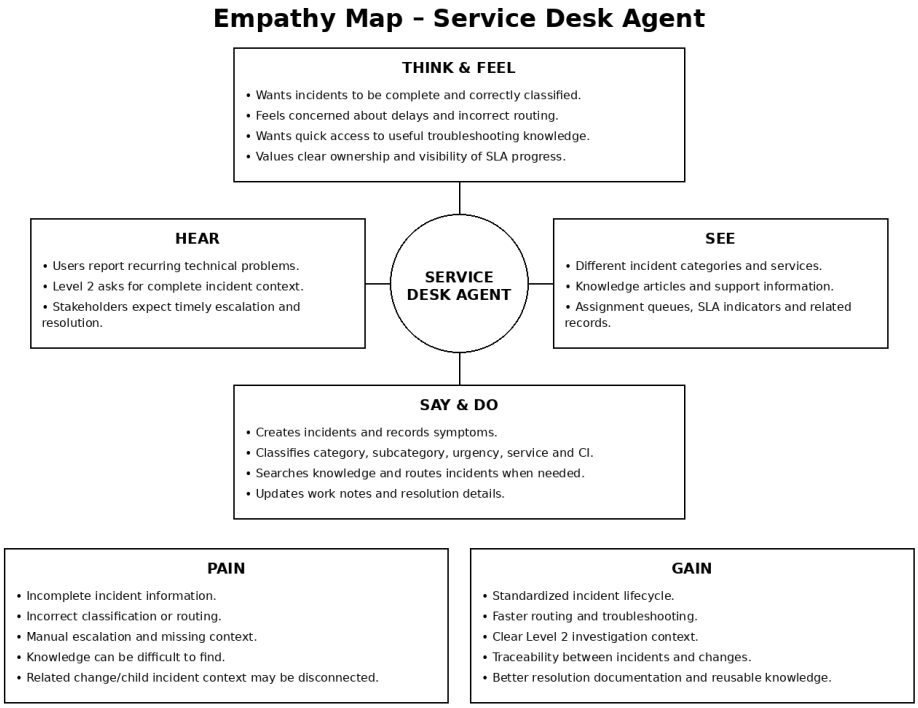


Figure 1: Empathy Map – Service Desk Agent

Component	Observations
Think & Feel	• Wants incidents to be complete and correctly classified. • Feels concerned about delays and incorrect routing. • Wants quick access to useful troubleshooting knowledge. • Values clear ownership and visibility of SLA progress.
Hear	• Users report recurring technical problems. • Level 2 asks for complete incident context. • Stakeholders expect timely escalation and resolution.
See	• Different incident categories and services. • Knowledge articles and support information. • Assignment queues, SLA indicators and related records.
Say & Do	• Creates incidents and records symptoms. • Classifies category, subcategory, urgency, service and CI. • Searches knowledge and routes incidents when needed. • Updates work notes and resolution details.
Pain	• Incomplete incident information. • Incorrect classification or routing. • Manual escalation and missing context. • Knowledge can be difficult to find. • Related change/child incident context may be disconnected.
Gain	• Standardized incident lifecycle. • Faster routing and troubleshooting. • Clear Level 2 investigation context. • Traceability between incidents and changes. • Better resolution documentation and reusable knowledge.

4. Goals

The Service Desk Agent wants to:

- **Create:** log each incident with the complete information needed to understand the issue.
- **Classify:** set category, subcategory, urgency, service and CI correctly.
- **Assign:** send the incident to the right team without delay.
- **Investigate:** find useful knowledge quickly and see related records and changes.
- **Resolve:** record the cause and resolution clearly so the incident can be closed with confidence.

5. Pain Points

- **Incomplete information:** missing details make it hard to classify, route and investigate the incident.

- **Incorrect routing:** incidents may reach the wrong team and wait longer for support.
- **Manual escalation:** handing over to Level 2 by hand can leave out important context.
- **Missing knowledge:** useful troubleshooting information can be difficult to find.
- **Disconnected related records:** change and child incident context may sit apart from the main incident.

6. Expected Gains

A structured incident lifecycle is expected to give the Service Desk Agent:

- **Consistency:** a standard way to create and classify every incident.
- **Visibility:** clear view of ownership, SLA progress and related records.
- **Better investigation:** faster routing and easier access to knowledge.
- **Smoother escalation:** clear context for the Level 2 Technician.
- **Better resolution documentation:** clear records and reusable knowledge from successful solutions.

7. Key Insight

The Service Desk Agent needs a structured incident process that makes classification, knowledge access, escalation, related-record tracking and resolution documentation easier and more consistent.